Non-Charging for Services in Compliance with Head Start Performance Standards

Performance Standard

§ 1302.18 Fees

a) *Policy on fees.* A program must not charge eligible families a fee to participate in Head Start, including special events such as field trips, and cannot in any way condition an eligible child's enrollment or participation in the program upon the payment of a fee.

(b) *Allowable fees.*

(1) A program must only accept a fee from families of enrolled children for services that are in addition to services funded by Head Start, such as child care before or after funded Head Start hours. A program may not condition a Head Start child's enrollment on the ability to pay a fee for additional hours.

(2) In order to support programs serving children from diverse economic backgrounds or using multiple funding sources, a program may charge fees to private pay families and other non-Head Start enrolled families to the extent allowed by any other applicable federal, state or local funding sources.

Policy

In accordance with the Head Start Performance Standards (1302.18), our program provides comprehensive services to eligible children and families at no charge. We recognize that the need for early childhood services is often greatest among the priority populations, including children from low-income families, children with disabilities, and those facing other barriers to access.

Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to ensure that our program adheres to the requirements outlined in the Head Start Performance Standards and maintains equitable access to services for all eligible families, particularly those within the identified priority populations.

Scope

This policy applies to all services provided under the Head Start program, including early childhood education, family engagement, health, nutrition, and other supportive services.

Policy Guidelines

Non-Charging for Services

As per Head Start Performance Standard 1302.18, our program does not charge families for any Head Start services. All services are provided at no cost to families, ensuring that children and families in priority populations receive the full benefits of the program without financial barriers.

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Performance Standard §1302.18 Fees

Priority Population Needs

We prioritize services for children and families who are at or below the federal poverty line and those who experience multiple barriers to accessing early childhood education. This includes children with disabilities, children experiencing homelessness, and children from underserved communities.

Financial Accessibility

Our program ensures financial accessibility by not requiring co-payments, tuition, or other fees from participating families. We are committed to meeting the needs of the priority populations as outlined in the Head Start Performance Standards, ensuring that every eligible child has an opportunity to benefit from the program's services.

Monitoring and Compliance

We will regularly review and monitor our policies to ensure ongoing compliance with the Head Start Performance Standards (1302.18) and the continued provision of free services to eligible families.

Implementation

The Program Director, in collaboration with staff, will ensure that all families are informed of the policy and are aware that no fees will be charged for any services. Communication materials and orientations will reflect this commitment to equitable service provision.

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